



ARMENIANS

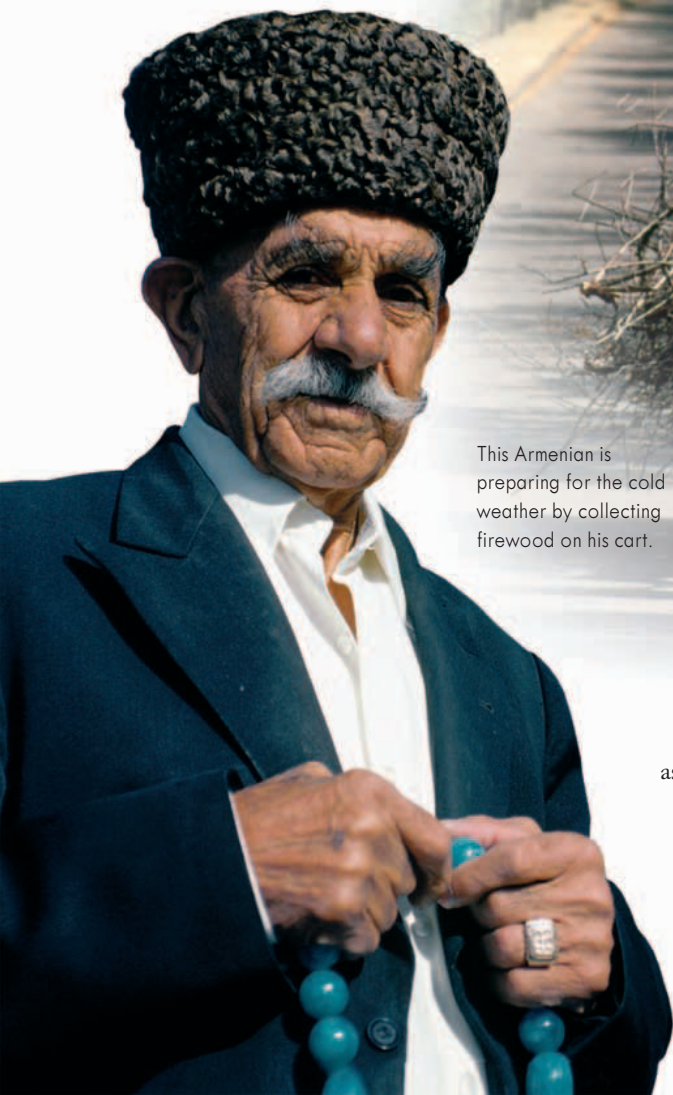
THE FIRST CHRISTIAN NATION

ARMENIA, ALONG WITH AZERBAIJAN AND GEORGIA, lies close to the Caucasus Mountains. Armenians are proud to be one of the world's ancient civilizations. They call themselves *Hayer* because they

A new republic

Armenia is the smallest of the independent states of the former Soviet Union. It became independent in 1991 with the demise of communism, and since then the culture has changed. Many people work in the agricultural sector, religion is thriving again, and folk dancing and other traditions have been revived.

An elderly Armenian with his worry beads. Men gather with their beads in the evening to chat.



This Armenian is preparing for the cold weather by collecting firewood on his cart.



IN THE COUNTRYSIDE

There are over 900 small, rural communities in Armenia. After independence, previously state-owned farms became private. These provide work for the people, but farming depends on good weather. Recent droughts have led to crop failure, meaning poverty for many.



GROWING ECONOMY

Armenia's economy relies on agriculture, with nearly half the population working on small, family-run farms. Stalls of homegrown produce, such as apples, grapes, and apricots, are a common sight in markets and along the roadside.

THE ARMENIAN CHURCH

In 301 AD, Armenia became the first nation to accept Christianity as its state religion. The Armenian Church (along with the Russian and Greek Orthodox Churches) is part of the Eastern Church.

These worshippers are lighting candles during a morning service in a cathedral.

